

Rain, rain go away: In Brisbane, the players spent more time in the pavilion watching the rain than actually playing. ^{AP}

Wagging tail

Steve Smith and Travis Head post centuries as Australia asserts itself in the first innings. India's reply, helmed by K.L. Rahul at the top and Ravindra Jadeja in the lower order, hits a rough spot as a follow-on has to be avoided. The last pair of Akash Deep and Jasprit Bumrah pulls off a miracle; the visitor's dressing room explodes with laughter and high-fives. There is something nerve-popping and equally laughter-inducing whenever the tail wags. But Akash and Bumrah have self-belief, and India survives for another day.

In a Test where the players spent more time in the pavilion watching the rain than actually playing, Australia gambles on its second innings in a bid to set a target; wickets tumble, a declaration is effected, and while the Indians make their tentative steps in their second dig, the rains have the last word. A draw is earned; India couldn't have asked for more, while Australia believes that it gained a moral victory.

Ashwin's googly

The third Test's climax ushers in a thrilling draw, and yes, cricket does

throw up this oxymoron. But cynical sports writers now have to play detective. Word spreads that a big retirement is around the corner, and many eyes from the press box seek clues from the Indian dressing room. Television grabs sourced through social media are scoured. X, formerly Twitter, is abuzz.

One eye on the match and rains, and the other eye on whatever can be gleaned from the pavilion, the scribes discuss. Rohit Sharma? Virat Kohli? And then a visual is obtained: Kohli hugging R. Ashwin. Ah, so the legend from Chennai, then?

Once the wet dust settles on the match, Ashwin strides into the press conference with Rohit. The wait is over. "This will be the last day for me as an international cricketer," Ashwin says. He speaks a bit more, hugs Rohit, and leaves. The captain then deals with a flurry of questions about this massive departure. "It's a personal decision; I somehow convinced him to play at Adelaide," the skipper says.

The sports writers rush back to the press box. Match report, Ashwin tribute, reactions, and media interaction updates have to be filed. It is a mad rush; keyboards clatter and words leap. A gritty draw, a storied career's closure — surely it is all happening at the Gabba.

Melbourne beckons

The next morning is a blur. Early

morning flights are a necessary evil, and bleary-eyed cricket writers hop onto a flight to Melbourne, the glorious city with its four seasons in one day feel. By the time the apartment is secured, the laundry done, and a late lunch tucked into, Ashwin is already in Chennai!

The Melbourne Cricket Ground (MCG) is one of cricket's spectacular venues. It is a theatre with an eternal vibe. As the road snakes past an ancient church, slips under a railway overbridge, and weaves past an expansive park redolent with eucalyptus fragrance, the stadium's floodlights shimmer into view.

Dennis Lillee and Shane Warne are all frozen as statues in their delivery stride. There is history in every corner. But the present beckons as the Indian team strides into nets. Located at a lower level, the training is watched by sports hacks and fans congregating at an upper level. This is a bird's-eye view with a difference.

Christmas Day is all about the family and fun, at least for the Australian cricketers. Pat Cummins and company, along with partners, wives, girlfriends, toddlers, are sprawled all over the MCG's turf. Debutant Sam Konstas soaks in the atmosphere.

The stage is set for the Boxing Day Test, an annual ritual Down Under.

